

PTI

NEW PURPOSE West Bengal BJP leader Suvendu Adhikari and others at an anti-government rally in Birbhum district, Nov. 25

Party insiders say even before the Bihar votes were counted, Shah and party president J.P. Nadda had a series of closed-door meetings with *sangathan mantris* (organisation ministers) and state *prabharis* (in-charges) from Bengal to finalise the campaign structure. Like in Bihar, the state is being divided into five operational zones, each managed by an organisational secretary (loaned from the RSS) and a senior leader who will camp in Bengal till the polls are over. The five zones are Purulia-Bardhaman, Howrah-Hooghly-Medinipur, Kolkata Metropolitan & South 24 Parganas, Nabadwip & North 24 Parganas and North Bengal (Malda-Siliguri division).

Meanwhile, the state unit is keeping busy, reviving the booth committees. It also claims to have covered 70,000 of the state's 81,000 booths by now. The SIR has provided an opportunity for deeper mapping and update of voter lists. "In 2021, we had enthusiasm without data," says a senior state office-bearer. "Now we have both." On December 3, as PM Modi met his MPs from Bengal to review the party's organisational preparedness, he asked about local challenges and assured all support in expansion efforts. The Sangh, too, has stepped up, with its affiliates expanding their footprint into rural districts. "The RSS is in the villages, not on TV," says a Kolkata-based analyst. "That's where the next election will be decided."

THE SOUTHERN CHALLENGE

Three states in the South go to the polls early next year, but Tamil Nadu will be the bumper contest. The BJP has pivoted to alliance politics again here after replacing polarising state chief K. Annamalai with ex-AIADMK legislator Nainar Nagendran. The shift in leadership was largely driven by caste arithmetic: Annamalai and AIADMK chief Edappadi K. Palaniswami, always at loggerheads, belong to the Gounder community. So, the party took the caste over-representation excuse to ease him out and instal Nagendran, who is from the dominant Thevar community.

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Electorally, the party's parliamentary performance improved in vote share (11.3 per cent), but the experiment in going it alone brought no other gains. The calculation is that by reviving the alliance with the AIADMK, balancing caste representation and combining it with the national narrative, the anti-DMK vote can be consolidated. The BJP is targeting seats in southern Tamil Nadu (where the Thevars are influential) and those in mixed population semi-urban areas where community arithmetic and alliance strength intersect.

Meanwhile, Kerala remains the BJP's most challenging frontier in the South, with the party now pursuing a